General rule – passive Perception · "Playing the Game" chapter of SRD 5.2.1

A **passive check** is a check without a roll: it's the **average** you'd get by taking 10. The passive score is **10 + all modifiers** to the check. **Advantage** adds 5; **Disadvantage** subtracts 5.

Passive Perception is used to spot what's hidden without calling for a roll: ambush, trap, sneaky creature.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. Passive score = **10 + modifiers** to the check.
2. Advantage: **+5**; Disadvantage: **−5**.
3. Useful for Perception, Insight, Investigation.
4. The DM compares to the DC or the Stealth check.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 keeps the rule; the **Search** action replaces the old active search.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD doesn't say when to use passive instead of a roll. Fix: passive for continuous watchfulness, a roll for active searching.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe a subtle clue ("a glint in the shadows") for characters with high passive Perception.

Step 1 – Calculate:

10 + Wisdom modifier + Perception proficiency if any.

Step 2 – Adjust:

Advantage: +5. Disadvantage: −5.

Step 3 – Compare:

The DM compares to the foe's Stealth or the trap's DC.

Step 4 – Resolve:

Score ≥ DC: the character notices. Otherwise, they can use the Search action.

Step 5 – Other passives:

Passive Insight, passive Investigation: same calculation.

Example: Wisdom +2, proficiency +2: passive Perception 14. A rogue gets 13 on Stealth: they're spotted.

Situation	Passive score
Normal Perception	10 + Wis + proficiency
With Advantage	15 + Wis + proficiency
With Disadvantage	5 + Wis + proficiency
Passive Insight	10 + Wis + proficiency (Insight)
Passive Investigation	10 + Int + proficiency (Investigation)
Expertise	Doubled proficiency in the calculation

⚠ Common questions:

Do I roll a die?

No: the passive value is fixed.

When to use it?

For continuous watchfulness: ambush, trap, prowler.

Can I use a roll instead?

Yes: the Search action allows an active check.

Does passive change with states?

Yes: Advantage +5, Disadvantage −5.

A sleeping character?

Reduced or none; the DM decides.

Is passive a check?

Yes, but with no roll.

Who knows the passive score?

The DM; players may note it on the sheet.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Stealth vs passive

A Stealth check against passive. **Option**: DC = each observer's passive.

Group watch

One passive for the group. **Option**: the highest.

Passive and sleep

Does sleeping reduce passive? **Option**: −5.

Hidden clues

Clues below the passive threshold. **Option**: give a clue if the player asks.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Average value

10 is a d20 average; passive uses it.

Advantage

+5, not a second die: matches d20 arithmetic.

Passive check

Counts as a check to trigger effects, without rolling.

Search

The Search action allows an active Wisdom roll.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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